ILLUSTRATION BY **RAJ VERMA**

families saw financial services as a safe option for their women—typically, these were in large cities and well-protected. "In many ways, the sector became a natural magnet. The consumer sector simply because women had a better and a natural understanding," points out Girotra. Over time, one saw more women move into technology, a big recruiter from engineering colleges.

The break into manufacturing has been a big story that has developed quietly, with large companies such as Ashok Leyland and Tata Motors leading the way. Girotra refers to Mahindra & Mahindra, where 17% of the leadership today are women from only 3% seven years ago.

To be sure, some of these sectors are incredibly hard to be in. One deals with regulation, technology disruption, huge impact of geopolitics, the constant need to raise capital – and these are only a handful of issues to contend with. In a world where today is as close to history as one can imagine, planning for tomorrow is onerous.

Understandably, this journey needs one to be surrounded by high-quality talent. For Hebbar, the biggest learnings have come from engineers and operational teams at her company's mines and smelters. Terming them "valuable mentors", she realised good strategy must withstand the realities of execution. That's not all. "Composure under pressure is a discipline and it is people closest to an operation who often have the clearest understanding of its challenges," she adds.

Then, there is the issue of dealing with expectations, making it a constant reality check. When Hebbar took charge of Hindustan Zinc, there were questions from people close to her. "My father wondered if I was thinking big enough, the engineers were asking whether I would earn it on the ground, and my mother wanted to know if my values would stay intact," she describes in some detail.

In times to come, the challenge (and the opportunity) will come from technology and, more specifically, AI. Girotra thinks women will have a big role to play here. "It's about them having high EQ," she says. In